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caskade: building Pythonic scientific simulators

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Summary

Scientific simulators and pipelines form the core of many research projects. Writing high quality, modular code allows for efficiently scaling a project, but this can be challenging in a research context. Research project goals and solutions to those goals are constantly in flux, requiring many refactoring rounds to meet these changes. The result can be a progressively more unwieldy interconnected code. Here we present a system, caskade, which allows users to focus on modular components of a simulator, these are small and testable to ensure robustness. With caskade one can turn these modular components into abstracted blocks that connect to form a powerful simulator. caskade manages the flow of parameter values through such a simulator.

Statement of Need

Science is an intrinsically iterative process, and so is the development of scientific code. Well written code is flexible and scalable while being performant, this is difficult to achieve in a scientific context where goals often evolve rapidly, requiring code refactoring. A major aspect of this is the parameters of a scientific model, the values that will ultimately be sampled and/or optimized to represent some data. A value may need to alternately be fixed, then allowed to vary (e.g. in Gibbs sampling). Some parameters that were initially separate may need to share a value or some functional relationship. In the extreme, a whole simulator may become a function of a single variable, such as time. Meta-data such as the uncertainty or valid range of a parameter may need to be stored. One may need to represent all parameters as a single 1D vector to interface with external tools, such as emcee (Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013), scipy.optimize (Virtanen et al., 2020), Pyro (Bingham et al., 2019), dynesty (Speagle, 2020), and torch.Optim (Paszke et al., 2019). Large projects and correspondingly large teams require the ability to break projects into manageable subtasks which can later be naturally combined into a complete analysis suite. Most importantly, as all of the above needs change, it is critical to meaningfully re-use older code without "code debt" or "software entropy" growing unsustainably.

Features

The core features of caskade are the `Module` base class, `Param` object, and `forward` decorator. To construct a caskade simulator, one subclasses `Module` then adds some number of `Param` objects as attributes of the class. Any number of class methods may be decorated with `@forward`,

meaning caskade will manage the Param arguments of that function. As modules are combined into a larger simulator, caskade builds a directed acyclic graph (DAG) representation. This allows it to automatically manage the flow (cascade) of parameters through the simulator and encode arbitrary relationships between them. This is inspired by the PyTorch framework nn.Module which allows for near effortless construction of machine learning models. We generalize the object oriented framework to apply to almost any scientific forward model, simulator, analysis pipeline, and so on; caskade manages the flow of parameters through these models. In some ways caskade is reminiscent of Hydra (Yadan, 2019), however caskade focuses on numerical parameters and scientific inference. The two may even be used in tandem.

Thus the primary capability of caskade is the management of Param values as they enter @forward methods of Modules. Any parameter may be transformed between "static" and "dynamic" where static has a fixed value and dynamic is provided at call time. Individual parameters or whole branches of the DAG may be switched between static and dynamic. Parameters may be synced with arbitrary functional relationships between them. New parameters may be added dynamically to allow for sophisticated transformations. For example, an entire simulator may be turned into a function of time without modifying the underlying simulator by adding a time parameter and linking appropriately. It is possible to use caskade with NumPy (Harris et al., 2020), JAX (Bradbury et al., 2018), or PyTorch (Paszke et al., 2019) numerical backends.

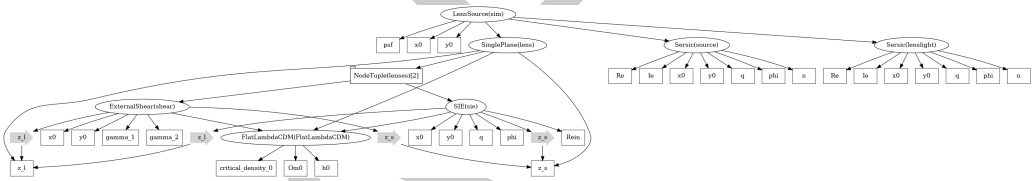

Figure 1: Example caskade DAG representation of a gravitational lensing simulator. Ovals represent Modules, boxes represent parameters, arrow boxes represent parameters which are functionally dependent on another parameter, and thin arrows show the direction of the graph flow for parameters passed at the top level.

Our suggested design flow is to build out a functional programming base for the package, then use Modules as wrappers for the functional base to design a convenient user interface. This design encourages modular development and is supportive of users who wish to expand functionality at different levels. The caustics package (Stone et al., 2024) implements this code design to great effect. Figure 1 shows an example caskade graph[1] from caustics. In this graph the redshift parameters of each lens are linked to ensure consistent evaluation despite the functional backed having no explicit enforcement of this. See also that all of the lens objects (ExternalShear, SIE, and SinglePlane) point to a single cosmology Module and so share the same cosmological parameters automatically.

The caskade package maintains 100% coverage for unit testing. Further, we include tutorial notebooks which demonstrate all of the available features. The caustics package can serve as a project template utilizing the many features of caskade.

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[1] visual generated by graphviz (Ellson et al., 2004)

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